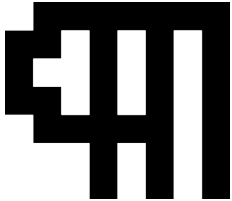

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The Journal of Reinhart

2024 October 12: Pacing
2024 October 18: Nosferatu

a mini pilcrow.monster/*zine*

2024 October 12: Pacing

In which I contemplate an element of narrative and my mixed feelings about it's perceived importance, and related general musings.

A couple of years ago I finally joined TikTok, and, after some algorithm-training about the things I actually wanted to see and those I wanted to avoid, overall I have found it a fascinating platform. I've got some videos on there, but it's hard to find the time and enthusiasm to post with any regularity. Anyway. I discover'd the crazy world of BookTok!

BookTok has had a not-insignificant impact on

the publishing industry. Not everybody is happy about that. Like any social media platform, the most entertaining, loud, and opinionated people get boosted the most by the algorithm. This leads to a lot of weird book discourse. A lot of bad takes like audiobooks don't count as reading, or the peculiar habit of only reading dialogue, or skipping any poetry. It might also have led to the rise of, gasp!, *Romantasy*, and also takes that this Romance/Fantasy subgenre is taking over Fantasy in general.

But that's all by-the-by. I want to discuss a somewhat less sexy subject: pacing. Why is it that I almost always get frustrated when reviews start complaining about pacing issues, whether it's that the pacing is too slow, or too uneven? To begin with, I think pacing is a lot more important in visual media like films and comics, and less so in books. I particularly find myself being irked when the complaint is that the pacing is too slow; I just want to unhumbly suggest that maybe the reviewer isn't patient enough! Take your time and maybe read with more consideration for the character development, and exploration of the world of the story.

The complaint is often levied against Tolkien. Perhaps this is the source of my disgruntlement. You don't disparage J.R.R., man! It seems to be a

plea for action, a plea for plot progression, a plea for excitement and entertainment. We should not reduce books, of all things, to these few aspects. Many books call for so much more than merely action and entertainment, and require so much more of an active engagement with the reader, as opposed to the more passive engagement of a movie.

Crank, starring Jason Statham, is defined by it's fast pacing. Think Speed, but instead of a vehicle that can't slow down or else it'll explode, it's Statham's heart; he has to keep his heart rate up-up-up or he'll die. It's maybe the Stathamest of all the Statham movies. You don't get much in the way of character development or plot. And of course Crank 2: High Voltage exists. Movies only have 90-120ish minutes to keep your attention. Comics generally only have 32 pages, and I can usually read an issue in 15 minutes or so, depending on how long I linger on the artwork. There are plenty of books that follow this basic tactic, and thrillers do sell excellently, year after year.

Don't expect Tolkien to follow that mode. Or anyone following in his general footsteps. I am glad that the fantasy genre has grown beyond Tolkien's influence, but there are still plenty of lessons to be learned from his narratives. One of those lessons is

that you are allowed to slow down your narrative, let your characters catch a breath, take a trip, explore and observe the world around them; take their time to ponder their places in that world, in that narrative, and wax philosophic. The benefits of this tactic are manifold: as a reader you get to experience the world of the narrative more deeply, connect with the characters more personally. You become invested. It does often take some patience and perseverance on the part of the reader. If you're listening to the audiobook, maybe slow it back down from the 3x speed you usually listen at, and actively listen. Try not to skim over the descriptive passages. Revel in them as I do! If the author is any good at a sentence level, indulge yourself in listening to the music of the prose, and if you're not listening to the audiobook, maybe read it out loud to yourself. Feel the language, the vibrations it makes. (Also, thinking of Tolkien, don't skip the goddam poems!! They are as much a part of the narrative he's building as anything else.)

Literature, also, is not music. It does not necessarily need the ebbs and flows of a symphony or concerto or pop song. An author might choose to use that analogy to structure their writing, and I imagine it would work well. Truthfully, I'm not entirely sure why the idea of uneven pacing, and why

it might be bad, irks me. Maybe because I don't tend to even consider it when I'm reading something. I have an aversion to that level of critique, generally. I don't want to feel as though I have strict criteria to judge what I'm reading: I just want to take each book as it comes, and take it for what it is; recognize maybe what the book is trying to be, and considering whether it is that thing, or not, despite itself, and either way the book could be incredible; a lot of truly excellent books do not fit comfortably into any one category.

"Old soul" is what adults would call me when I was young. Never knew how to react that, really. Thanks? They meant it as a compliment, obviously, but to my mind it just meant I didn't fit in that great with my peers (which was true, let's face it). But I have, privately, always been a bit of a curmudgeon. It's not my favorite aspect of myself. Even in middle school I was thinking "kids these days". If anything I think I've softened since then. Kids these days, from what I've seen, are, on the whole, all right. You know, as all right as kids have *ever* been.

So yeah, when I find myself getting irritated by

the weird opinions of others, I try to avoid thinking what's WRONG with these people?, rather why might this be a take at all, valid or not? Where's this coming from? Pacing is possibly the least of these, but a good place to start; a small thing to get off my chest. Eases the need to gripe elsewhere.

I make no bones about these posts being a bit rambly but I mostly try to stay on topic. A strange side-effect of the rise of what is popularly referred to as AI, is that I feel justified in leaning into my personal, stream-of-consciousness style, being a little weird, with run-on sentences and a love of alliteration. Let's ya'll know I'm human. In another era I might be typing this up on a typewriter and photocopying and stapling and dispersing thru the zine scene. The beautiful thing is that even in this era, the zine scene is thriving; people choosing to go low tech, hands on, create a personal physical artifact. Love that shit.

2024 October 18: Nosferatu

In which I discourse upon the joys of seeing the 1922 grand-daddy of horror films with a live orchestra in a packed theater.

Last night my wife and I went to a showing of Nosferatu at The Mayan Theatre in Denver, CO.; F.W. Murnau's masterpiece from over a century ago. Live music was provided by Quarkestra, also Denver based, who have also scored Metropolis. Their music is available on Bandcamp, and most likely all the other places. The score is synced with the 2013 release from KinoLorber.

They... they also did foley effects! Clippy-cloppy horses, the insane laughter of Knock, a million other things I didn't even think twice about, all timed impeccably and done live.

The audience, too, was very engaged and enthusiastic, and skewed towards the millenials from what I could see. I think it makes sense for Denver to be a good place for such things. The man who introduced the film asked the crowd how many had never seen a silent film. A handful of hands (if such a phrase works) went up, which gratified the man who said on previous occasions at least a quarter of the room would raise their hands. There were several points throughout the film, but mostly near the beginning, that the audience found very funny. Mostly with good reason: our hero, Hutter, is such a great silent film actor-type, very expressive, not too bright. The audience also laughed at the werewolf, which was clearly, to our modern eyes, a hyena, and pretty small compared to the horses it was frightening. Not exactly the big hulking CGI grotesque we think of nowadays when we think of modern movie werewolves. Cries of *awwwwww!* could be heard on the close-ups of the hyena (I can sympathize to a degree, but I also wouldn't want to come face to face with a hyena in the wild, would

you?). That same person made distressed noises later on when one of the dockworker's feet were covered in rats, he's bitten, and proceeds to try to whack some of them. I wanted to remind that audience member that the film talked heavily about the plague, and what animal traditionally brings the freakin' plague?? Whack them plague rats!

I had forgotten that as Count Orlok arrives at his destination, a seeming plague follows him. No one knows what's killing the sailors and dockworkers, and all the townsfolk are ordered to quarantine. Flashbacks to just a few years ago with covid. To give some historical context with the film, 1922 was only a few years past the Spanish flu epidemic, which I'm just now discovering had very little to do with Spain, specifically. Wikipedia calls it the Great Influenza epidemic, one of history's worst. And of course this is very shortly after the Great War, as well. The setting, though, is in 1838 Germany.

Seeing this was such a strong reminder that this is how these movies especially are supposed to be seen: projected, with an audience, with live music. A hundred years maybe they played records, rather than always live music, I'm not sure. Live music is much my preferred way. Back in college I had the pleasure of seeing a pianist from Chicago play live

for a showing of Phantom of the Opera. That was much less involved, and I think, if I recall aright, that the pianist improvised a lot of what he did. What he did was very good. What we saw last night was incredibly rehearsed for sure, to everybody's benefit. All four(?) members of Quarkestra appear to be multi-instrumentalists, and their love and enthusiasm for silent film comes through their score. I got pleasurable chills in several of the most iconic scenes, largely due to their incredible emotional impact of the music.

The film is in the public domain, and as such can be seen in various forms on YouTube, the Internet Archive, and so forth.

It is not exactly the most subtle of vampiric tales, but it so gosh dang iconic and so amazingly influential on cinema at large. Possibly the simplistic fairy tale aspect of it even helped keep it in the public's imagination. And to think the litigious Stoker estate tried to have the film eradicated from history for borrowing more-than-heavily from Bram's 1897 magnum opus *Dracula*. While Nosferatu may technically be a knock-off, it stands as its own take on the vampire legend. Werner Herzog remade it in 1979, with Klaus Kinski taking on Max Schreck's role of Orlok, the titular Nosferatu. For Christmas this year

of our lordy 2024 we're getting a new version from Robert Eggers, featuring Bill Skarsgård as Orlok, as well as Willem Dafoe, Nicholas Hoult. I'm curious about Herzog's version, and I'll be curious about Eggers's, though it does look legitimately terrifying:

Herzog's version also looks like it could be pretty terrifying, as well. What strikes me the most about watching the trailers is how much they reference the original; it's impossible to get away from, and why would you want to. I can see from a director's point of view the desire to expand the original, to remake the original film with modern technology and over 100 years worth of cinematic innovation.

Two more things before I end this post. I hear tell there's a film from 2000 called *Shadow of the Vampire*, which is a fictional dramatization of the making of the original *Nosferatu*. It stars Willem Dafoe as Max Schreck, who might actually be a vampire (I haven't yet seen it). It also stars Eddie Izzard, John Malkovich, Cary Elwes, and Udo Grier. How have I never heard of this before?!

And lastly, a journal entry from the French author and noted diarist, Andre Gide, dated Monday, 27 February 1929:

> Yesterday, *Nosferatu, the Vampire*.

A rather nondescript German film, but of a nondescript quality that forces one to reflect and to imagine something better. Terror, just like pity, can be excited in the mind of the spectator (at least of this spectator) only if he is not too much aware of the author's concern to move to terror or pity; furthermore, I doubt whether the classic precept:

> *If you wish me to weep, you yourself must grieve first.*
> (Horace: Epistolae, II, iii. 102-3.)

is a very good recipe.

In *Nosferatu* the hero's terror checks, gets in the way of mine. The hero, who is depicted as dashing, venturesome, and even very pleasingly bold, undergoes a dreadful change and passes from excessive joy to the expression of excessive terror. I should myself be more frightened if I were less aware of his being afraid.

If I were to make over the film, I should depict Nosferatu – whom we know to be the vampire from the start – not as terrible and fantastic, but on the contrary in the guise of an inoffensive young man, charming and most obliging. I should like it to be only on the basis of very mild indications, in the beginning, that any anxiety should be aroused, and in the spectator's mind before being aroused in the hero's. Likewise, wouldn't it be much more frightening if he were first presented to the woman in such a charming aspect? It is a kiss that is to be transformed into a bite. If he shows his teeth at the outset, it becomes nothing but a childish nightmare.

How much cleverer it would be, instead of constantly emphasizing that concern with terror, to pretend on the contrary a desire to reassure the spectator: No, not at all, there is nothing terrible there at all, nothing that is not quite natural; at most something a bit too charming; even though one might have to let Nosferatu be more open about it on the boat with the sailors.

Likewise for the pseudo-scientific part, presented here with a truly German heavy hand; absurd. How much cleverer it would have been, beside the fantastic explanation, to provide the spectator with a perfectly rational and plausible explanation based on this little precise fact that we all know: that a plague can be transmitted by rats!

In a well-constructed fantastic tale the mind must be able to be satisfied with the natural explanation. It must be almost able to suffice; but the narrator will go about it in such a way that the skeptic is he who does not happen to be satisfied with it. It is the materialistic and positivistic mind that must appear as naïve in this case.

The wonderful thing in Goethe's *Erlkönig*, for instance, is that the child is not so much terrified as charmed, that he surrenders to the mysterious blandishments the father does not see. At first all the fright is on the father's part. I should have wished that, likewise, the young woman of *Nosferatu*, though conscious of her sacrifice in the beginning, had lost that consciousness, so to speak, yielding to the vampire's charms, and that he had not been horrible in her eyes. It might be rather startling, furthermore, for the vampire to yield to the woman's

charms, to forget the hour. . . . I can easily see him appearing a hideous monster to everyone, and charming only in the eyes of the young woman, a voluntary, fascinated victim; but that, fascinated in turn, he should become less and less horrible until he really becomes the delightful person whose mere appearance he only took on at the first. And it is this delightful person that the cock's crow must kill, that the spectator must see suddenly disappear with relief and, at the same time, regret.

In short, a film that was completely spoiled.

Translated from the French & annotated by Justin O'Brien. Published 1949 (two years before Gide's death). Alfred A. Knopf : New York

Andre Gide would've made an incredible film critic. And with that, sleep tight, and don't let them Nosferatus bite!